

How Far Can They Walk Alone?

A short piece on independence, closeness, and the causative verbs that describe both — make, let, get, have, help. Written about two countries that answer the same question very differently: Brazil and Japan.

STUDENT

DATE

TEACHER

ARTICLE

At 7:15 on a Tokyo morning, a six-year-old in a yellow cap gets on the subway by himself, backpack half his size, and rides four stops to school. No parent in sight. At almost the same hour in São Paulo, a child the same age is walking to school holding an adult's hand, and will keep holding it for several more years. Neither scene looks strange to the people living inside it.

Japanese parenting has a name for this early trust: *jiritsu* (自立), independence built on purpose, starting young. Elementary schools **make** first-graders carry their own trays, serve their own lunch, and clean their own classroom — no staff assigned to it. A famous television show, *Hajimete no Otsukai* ("My First Errand"), simply films toddlers doing exactly that: their first solo errand to a shop down the street. A parent might **help** a child pack the school bag the night before, but quietly, by six, that help stops.

Brazilian parenting tells a different story about love. Affection is physical and constant — *colo* (being held, carried, kept close) is practically a value in itself, not just something babies need. Parents don't **let** a six-year-old ride the metro alone, not because they don't trust the child, but because closeness is the point, not an obstacle to grow out of. It sometimes **gets** visiting foreigners to ask, gently, if Brazilian kids are ever put down.

Grandparents, aunts, and family friends are woven into the system early. A mother in Rio might **have** her own mother pick the kids up from school twice a week — not because she's too busy, but because that's what a family is for. In Japan, the neighborhood itself often plays that role instead: a shopkeeper who makes sure a small customer gets home safely is usually enough.

"Neither country is wrong. They're just answering a different question."

By the time a Japanese child is ten, the walk to school has already **made** her comfortable reading a train map alone. By the time a Brazilian child is ten, the walk to school has usually **made** him fluent in a different skill: knowing exactly which uncle to call if he needs a ride.

What both countries seem to agree on, in the end, is that a child eventually has to be trusted — with a task, with a walk, with a choice. They just disagree about the calendar. Japan tends to trust early and expects the

VOCABULARY

errand

お使い
recado, tarefa

trust

信頼
confiança

closeness

親密さ
proximidade, apego

independence

自立
independência

neighborhood

近所
vizinhança

to grow into (something)

～に成長して適応する
crescer até se adaptar

woven into

織り込まれた
entrelaçado, parte de

on its own time

自然な時間で
no seu próprio tempo

child to grow into it. Brazil tends to hold on longer, trusting that letting go, when it finally happens, will happen on its own time.



Independence, Japanese-style: trained early, in small doses — a lunch tray, an errand, a subway ride.



Closeness, Brazilian-style: the value itself, not a phase to outgrow.



Two calendars, one destination: a child who can eventually be trusted alone.

STRUCTURE SPOTLIGHT

Five ways to say someone caused someone else to act.

CASE	STRUCTURE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
MAKE	make + object + base verb / adjective	force — no choice	Schools make first-graders carry their own trays.
LET	let + object + base verb	permission — full choice	Parents don't let a six-year-old ride alone.
GET	get + object + to + verb	persuade — takes effort	It gets visiting foreigners to ask questions.
HAVE	have + object + base verb	arrange — it's their role	A mother might have her own mother pick the kids up.
HELP	help + object + (to) + verb	assist — together	A parent might help a child pack the bag.

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WARM-UP · WHICH VERB CONVINCED YOU?

Each answer hides a synonym for one of the five causative verbs. Find the clue, then write the question.

01. Answer: "She **convinced** me to come earlier."

02. Answer: "He **forced** me to redo the report."

03. Answer: "She **allowed** me to leave early."

04. Answer: "He **arranged for** the mechanic to fix it."

05. Answer: "They **assisted** me in carrying the boxes."

06. Answer: "She **refused** to let me stay up late."

07. Answer: "The rain **forced** us to cancel the picnic."

08. Answer: "He **persuaded** the team to work overtime."

09. Answer: "She **permitted** her son to travel alone."

10. Answer: "I had my hair cut yesterday."

COMPREHENSION CHECK

Answer based on the text. No need for full sentences.

1. True or False: In Japan, schools assign staff to serve lunch to first-graders.

☐ T

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2. What is the Japanese TV show about first errands called?

3. True or False: In Brazil, closeness is described as something parents want children to grow out of quickly.

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☐ F

4. Besides the parents themselves, who else often helps pick up children in Brazil, according to the text?

5. According to the text, what do both countries seem to agree on, even though they disagree about the calendar?

6. True or False: The text says Brazil and Japan want completely different final outcomes for their children.

☐ T ☐ F

DISCUSSION

No right answer. Use the target verbs if you can.

1. Which pattern feels closer to how you were raised — the Japanese one or the Brazilian one? Give one example.

2. Do you think Brazilian cities could adopt the Japanese habit of letting children move around alone? Why or why not?

3. If you had children in Japan, what's one thing that would make you, as a Brazilian parent, uncomfortable at first?

NEXT PAGE → ANSWER KEY

ANSWER KEY

Comprehension check — try first, check after.

1. False — The text says schools make first-graders serve their own lunch — no staff assigned.
2. Hajimete no Otsukai (はじめてのおつかい)
3. False — The text says closeness is the point, not an obstacle to grow out of.
4. Grandparents, aunts, or family friends.
5. That a child eventually has to be trusted — with a task, a walk, or a choice.
6. False — They agree on the goal (trust); they disagree only about the timing.

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